

US–Iran Conflict Briefing

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The strikes that didn't happen: Trump called off last-minute Houthi airstrikes

- The New York Times reported that the Trump administration had prepared on Sunday to launch airstrikes against the Houthis after fresh pleas from Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman — but that Trump called off the strikes at the last minute, even as troops were loading bombs onto aircraft. Reuters could not independently verify the report; CENTCOM referred questions to the White House, which did not respond. — [New York Times \(via Reuters\)](#)
- Trump spoke by phone Sunday with Rashid al-Alimi, president of Yemen's Saudi-backed, internationally recognized government, who asked for US military help against the Houthis, four sources told Reuters; two sources said Trump made no direct pledge of support during the call. — [Reuters](#)
- Washington has so far rebuffed repeated Saudi pleas to join the fight in Yemen; the Houthis, who control Yemen's capital since 2014, seized the country's Red Sea coast earlier this month, routing Saudi-backed government forces. — [Reuters](#)

Houthis push into the highlands to cut off the Red Sea coast

- Houthi fighters pushed on Monday to seize strategic heights in Yemen to cut off the Red Sea coast from remaining areas held by Saudi-backed forces, extending the wider Middle East conflict to a new theater. — [Reuters](#)
- Yemen's government said Monday its forces struck Houthi fighters and supply lines in the Bab al-Mandeb area and in Bayda province; a senior commander claimed troops went on the offensive, though Houthi resistance — including from local tribes — remains stiff and the government still holds the critical Taiz–Aden road junction. Heavy fighting also reported in oil-rich Marib. — [CNN](#)
- Houthi spokesman Yahya Saree claimed Monday that Saudi Arabia carried out 157 aircraft and missile strikes across four Yemeni provinces, bringing the total to 917 since the latest escalation began, and vowed a response — claims CNN could not independently verify and Saudi authorities did not immediately address. — [CNN](#)
- The WHO reported 680 people killed or injured across Yemen in a single week (Sept 13–18): 164 killed and 516 injured, bringing the total since Aug 6 to 3,672 casualties including 674 deaths; Lahj province in southwestern Yemen is currently an active front line. — [AP](#)

Two tankers hit in the Strait of Hormuz on Monday

- The UK's Maritime Trade Operations center said an 'unknown projectile' struck a tanker on an inbound transit through the Strait of Hormuz on Monday; two crew members sustained minor injuries. The vessel continued to its next port of call under its own power with no environmental impact reported. — [AP](#)
- In a second Monday incident, an LPG tanker transiting outbound from the Strait of Hormuz was hit by debris from unknown projectiles, UKMTO said in a delayed report from the vessel's master; all crew were reported safe and the tanker continued to its next port of call. — [Reuters](#)

- No group has been attributed to either incident; UKMTO advised all vessels in the area to transit with caution and report suspicious activity. The two strikes follow a third tanker attack in the strait late last week, with Hormuz traffic far below pre-war levels. — [AP](#)

Geneva: the Iran report gets its first full debate

- In its Sept 21 statement, the EU thanked the fact-finding mission, condemned the continuous increase in executions, torture, and repression in Iran, and recalled the January crackdown in which Iranian security forces answered peaceful protesters with lethal force — tens of thousands arrested and killed, forced confessions, and a months-long nationwide internet shutdown. — [European External Action Service](#)
- The UK said it remains 'horrified' by the dire human rights situation in Iran, noted the report documents civilian deaths from the March 2026 conflict including in Minab, and reiterated support for the mission's work as essential to accountability and justice. — [UK government](#)

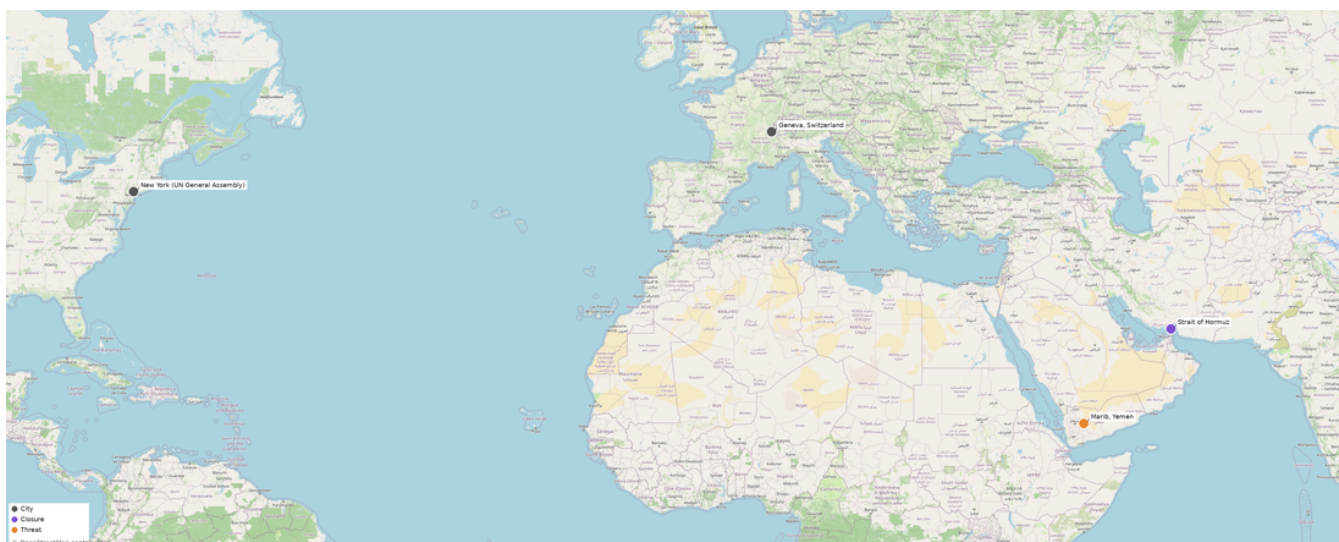
Oil holds near \$102 as UN week begins

- Brent crude held near \$102 a barrel through Monday — its lowest since early September — even as two tankers were hit in Hormuz and Yemen fighting escalated, with traders betting on the New York diplomatic window. — [Wall Street Journal](#)
- The UNGA high-level debate opens Tuesday in New York; Trump addresses the Assembly Tuesday and Pezeshkian Wednesday, with a possible Trump–Pezeshkian meeting still unconfirmed. — [AP](#)

What to watch next

- Whether the White House confirms or denies the Times account of the called-off Houthi strikes — and whether Trump reverses course.
- Whether the rumored Trump–Pezeshkian meeting at the General Assembly actually happens, and what Pezeshkian says Wednesday.
- The Houthi highlands offensive: whether the push to cut off the Red Sea coast succeeds or stalls against tribal and government resistance.
- Whether the Hormuz tanker attacks continue — and whether any group claims responsibility.
- The US embassy alert wave: whether more missions go to a harder warning posture.

Conflict map



Markers show reported strike sites, bases, and shipping areas. Purple polygons mark approximate or announced closure / exclusion zones.

Related media



A tanker transiting the Strait of Hormuz (file photo) — [view original](#)



President Donald Trump (AP photo) — [view original](#)

■ [Reuters live: the UN Human Rights Council's Iran debate in Geneva, September 21](#)

Sources: [New York Times \(via Reuters\)](#) · [Reuters](#) · [CNN](#) · [AP](#) · [Reuters](#) · [European External Action Service](#) · [UK government](#) · [Wall Street Journal](#)

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